Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

June 2023

A Gateway to World Markets for Indian Textiles

India's hand embroidered textiles have for long been prized within India. In recent decades, with the rise and rise of modern media, that aesthetic has rapidly enamoured discerning men and women across the world, particularly those in the affluent global north.

Chanakya International has led this movement from its Mumbai ateliers, where select and impossibly skilled bands of craftspeople create interpretations of Indian embroidery to exacting briefs provided by legendary fashion houses of Europe, the US and Canada.

This was recently reflected in the Dior 2023 show when Mumbai's monumental Gateway of India, panelled with an outsize Gujarati 'toran' made by the maestros of Chanakya and bordered by fresh flower carpets, was turned into a fashion runway against the cool March night sky. The invited audience included ultrachic luminaries of the fashion, cinema, sports and business worlds.

On that one evening, the reputation of Indian handmade shot sky high.



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The Chanakya School of Craft

Dior has long collaborated with Chanakya for bespoke embroideries but after the 2016 appointment of Maria Grazia Chiuri as the women's creative director of Dior, the relationship has taken on much more significant, and feminist, proportions.

From that time, the school began a long-term project of training women to become skilled embroiderers – a profession previously restricted to men. Women have always done a tremendous amount of fine needlework in India, but earlier they were restricted to working in their own homes.

Since the launch of the Chanakya School of Craft and thanks to Chiuri's mentoring, over 1,000 women have graduated from the 18-month course, allowing them to take on the profession in Indian ateliers, or to create their own businesses. A large number of the 700 artisans who are employed by Chanakya alone worked on the magnificent 'toran' that adorned the Gateway of India.

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